

High Tides

Lincoln Township Beach used to stretch a few hundred feet before the waves lapped up at its sand. Today, you can't get more than four steps down the rickety walkway before seeing the murky water lulling along a thin strip of sand. Cass sat in her car, nervously tapping her nails against the open window.

"...should we go down?" she asks, glancing at the passenger's seat where her best friend Zoe was, lips pursed. Her response lags.

"...yeah." Despite the response, it's Cass who gets out first. Their feet land on the sandy parking lot littered with food packages and cigarette butts. It wasn't the same beach Cass remembered taking family pictures on. That beach's sand was soft, shifting through her toes as she chased her brother.

The two walked for a bit, coming to a set of stairs that led down to the beach. Memories of the dreaded trek back up the steep stairs after a tiring day of swimming flash through their minds. Shells and rocks once dotted along the shore, shimmering under the clear water that now looked a bit, "Eugh", The disgusted sound leaves Zoe's throat as she looks down at the water, now speckled with dead flies and something dark. Their noses cringe as the smell of rotting fish and chemicals bullies its way in. "The water's almost hitting the bottom stair." she mutters as they halt at the top of the first step, looking down to what was once the beach. At the bottom of the sandy hill lay a thin strip of sand that was more grit and plastic than anything. Crows pick at fish skeletons while waves wash the same pieces of trash up onto the shore again.

“Yeah.” Cass scoffs in agreement, “Climate change won’t affect Lake Michigan, my ass. Can’t even remember the last time they tried to tell us that the tide was just gonna be high for a few years...the tides have been high for longer than I have and that’s...concerning.” she rants sarcastically, earning a small giggle from Zoe. The girls look at each other, scrunched cheeks and suppressed smiles breaking through the tense atmosphere.

“I appreciate it...you coming back for the protest tomorrow. Having the hometown hero fancy D.C. climate lawyer is gonna get people excited and probably pissed.” Cass adds after a few last chuckles. “Especially when she’s standing next to the person who organized the strike.”

Zoe looks over, grinning. “From forcing our parents to watch us perform in my basement to organizing climate strikes and fighting for climate justice in D.C. I’d say our moms succeeded in the whole “strong, independent daughters” thing wouldn’t you?” she says with a sly smirk, her eyes flitting over to me as the sun begins to set. The streaks of red and orange cutting through the sun as it lowers itself into the lake.

“Guess so.” Cass replies after a moment, returning the sly grin. They knew it’d take more than this strike, that things had continued to get worse despite the fighting, but change was starting. It was slow, but it was there, so they were too.